

ALI TUTORS

November Maths Plan

Edexcel IGCSE Mathematics A (4MA1) · Higher Tier

SIX WEEKS TO PAPER 1

For Charlotte and her parents · 21 September 2026

Two papers, two days apart

44

days until Paper 1

Six teaching weeks
and two days

Wed 4 Nov **Paper 1H**

Morning · 2 hours · 100 marks · calculator

Fri 6 Nov **Paper 2H**

Morning · 2 hours · 100 marks · calculator

Both papers allow a calculator, and both draw on the whole course.

Calculator technique is covered in the next session and checked before every timed piece of work. A topic that appears on Paper 1 is likely to appear again on Paper 2.

THE TARGET

The number we are working to

65

marks out of 200

The grade 5 boundary on Higher tier in November 2025, just under a third of the paper. Boundaries shift each series, so we treat this as a guide.

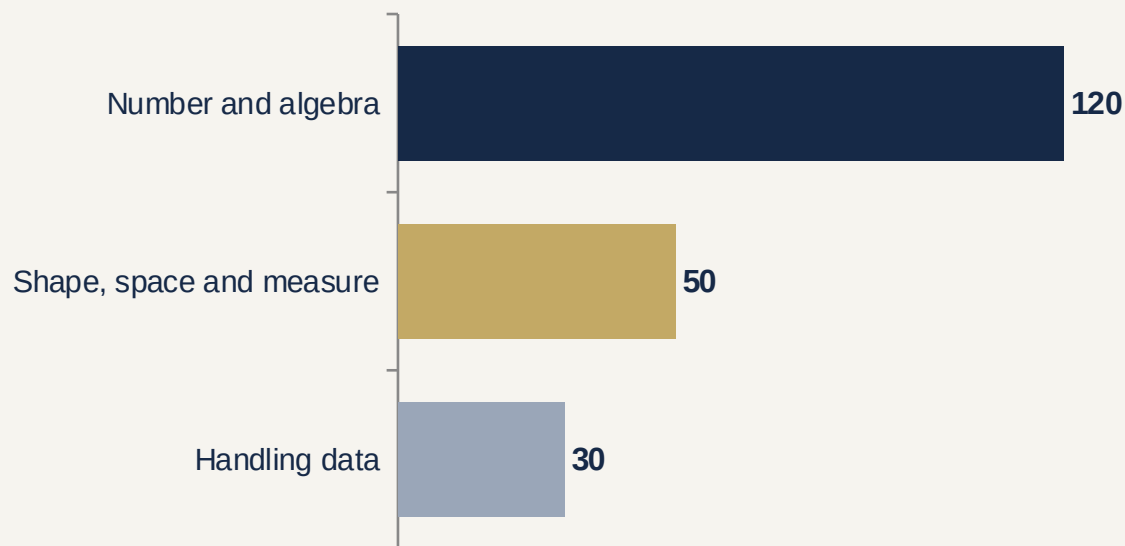
Grade	Marks needed	Share of total
Grade 6	86 / 200	43%
Grade 5	65 / 200	33%
Grade 4	45 / 200	23%

Why we work towards 80

Boundaries shift, so aiming at last year's number exactly leaves no room. The larger factor is how many marks Charlotte is taught to attempt in the first place, which the next slide sets out.

WHERE THE MARKS ARE

Number and algebra is about 60% of the marks



The largest section is also the weakest

Charlotte's gaps are concentrated in number and algebra. Work there pays back across about 120 marks, so the first three weeks stay on it.

Handling data does not depend on algebra

Averages, tables, probability and Venn diagrams are about 30 marks that the algebra gaps do not block. They come in week 4.

How many marks we cover

about 80 marks are pitched at grades 4 and 5

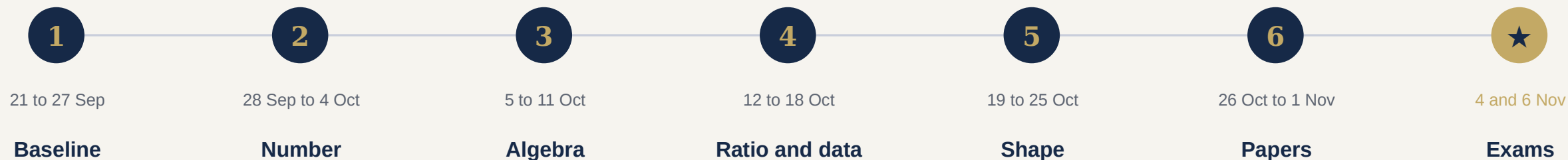
The specification puts about 40% of each paper at grades 4 and 5. Covering only that band means converting 65 of 80, leaving room to drop 15 marks.

about 105 marks once single-step grade 6 topics are added

The target to pass stays at 65, with room to drop 40 marks.

THE ROUTE

The six weeks



How the balance shifts

Weeks 1 and 2

80% teaching · 20% exam questions

Most of the time goes on content.

Weeks 3 to 5

Roughly half teaching, half timed work

Timed sections start short and lengthen.

Week 6

Full papers only, no new content

Two full papers, marked and reviewed.

Full papers come in weeks 1, 5 and twice in week 6, with timed sections in weeks 3 and 4.

That gives three rounds of feedback with time left to act on each one.

PAST PAPERS

How they are used, and from when

Past papers do two jobs here, and we use them differently for each.

Questions, from the next session

Every topic is practised on real exam questions rather than textbook exercises.

- Topic-sorted questions while the topic is being covered
- Mixed and ungrouped in the daily practice, so the method has to be chosen first
- Marked against the published mark scheme
- Anything wrong goes into the error log

Whole papers, four of them

Timed, under exam conditions, on set dates. These are how we measure progress.

- | | |
|---------------|--------------------------------------|
| WEEK 1 | Baseline paper, at home, timed |
| WEEK 5 | Full paper under exam conditions |
| WEEK 6 | Two full papers, marked and reviewed |

The baseline uses a past paper rather than the specimen, since part of the specimen has already been seen.

About twelve hours in total, including the marking.

MARKING

A paper is only worth the time if it is marked and reviewed. Charlotte marks each one against the published mark scheme, and the session afterwards covers her five biggest losses.

WHY NOT MORE

There is no shortage of 4MA1 papers, so the limit is time. A full paper costs two hours to sit and one to review. In weeks 2 to 4 those hours are better spent on teaching and short timed sections.

Starting with the foundations

1

WEEK 1 · 21 to 27 Sep

Baseline and setup

- Fluency audit: 35 questions, 50 minutes
- Calculator setup: fraction key, ANS and STO, standard form, table mode, degree mode
- The formula sheet: what is provided, so no time goes on learning it
- Method marks: how working earns marks
- Setting up the error log

AT HOME

Baseline paper at home, 2 hours, timed. Daily practice: negatives in algebra.

PAPER WORK

Baseline paper, reviewed together in session two

2

WEEK 2 · 28 Sep to 4 Oct

Number

- Fractions: all four operations
- Percentage multipliers, increase and decrease
- Reverse percentages
- Standard form and index laws
- One method per topic, used every time

AT HOME

Daily practice: negatives and fractions.

PAPER WORK

Topic questions on percentages

Algebra, then the data topics

3

WEEK 3 · 5 to 11 Oct

Algebra

- Collecting terms and expanding brackets
- Solving with x on both sides
- Substitution and rearranging formulae
- Linear simultaneous equations
- Audit repeated (checkpoint 1)

AT HOME

Daily practice: fractions and percentages.

PAPER WORK

Timed section, 25 minutes, two-pass rule applied

4

WEEK 4 · 12 to 18 Oct

Ratio, data and graphs

- Ratio and proportion by the unitary method
- Averages and frequency tables
- Estimated mean from grouped data
- Probability, tree diagrams and Venn diagrams
- Sequences and straight-line graphs

AT HOME

Daily practice: solving and ratio.

PAPER WORK

Timed section, 40 minutes, marked against the mark scheme

Shape, then papers

5

WEEK 5 · 19 to 25 Oct

Shape and space

- Angle facts, area and perimeter
- Circles, prisms and cylinders
- Pythagoras and right-angled trigonometry
- Similar shapes: area and volume ratios
- Audit repeated (checkpoint 2)

AT HOME

Daily practice: all six target skills, mixed.

PAPER WORK

First full paper, 2 hours, exam conditions

6

WEEK 6 · 26 Oct to 1 Nov

Papers

- Review and correct the week 5 paper
- Second full paper, then the five biggest losses
- Third full paper if the first two are on target
- Pacing and exam technique session
- No new content after 25 October

AT HOME

Daily practice: from the error log.

PAPER WORK

Two full papers, plus a third if week 5 reached 35 out of 100

EXAM WEEK

2 to 6 November

MON 2 NOV

Last session

No new content. A run through everything covered, a pacing rehearsal and a calculator check, finishing on a topic Charlotte is confident with.

WED 4 NOV

Paper 1H

Morning, 2 hours, 100 marks. Two passes: the recognisable questions first, then back to anything flagged. The last ten minutes for checking.

THU 5 NOV

The day between

No full review of the paper. We go back to the questions Charlotte started and left, where a mark is often one line away, then cover the two or three topics she could not begin.

FRI 6 NOV

Paper 2H

Morning, 2 hours, 100 marks. Same pacing. Both papers draw on the whole course, so topics from Wednesday will come up again.

No new content after 25 October. The remaining time is for consolidation. Results are released to candidates on 21 January 2027.

What we cover, and what we leave out



Covered

About 105 marks sit in this list, comfortably above the target.

- Fractions, decimals, percentages, reverse percentages
- Negatives, indices, standard form, rounding
- Ratio and proportion by the unitary method
- Solving, expanding, substituting, rearranging
- Linear simultaneous equations
- Sequences and straight-line graphs
- Angles, area, circles, prisms, Pythagoras, trigonometry
- Similar shapes: area and volume ratios
- Averages, frequency tables, probability, Venn diagrams



Left out

Worth 60 to 80 marks, and unlikely to repay the time in six weeks.

- Circle theorems and their proofs
- Vectors and vector geometry
- Histograms with unequal class widths
- Algebraic fractions, functions, graph transformations
- Surds, bounds, 3D trigonometry
- Quadratic formula, sine and cosine rules
- Quadratic simultaneous equations

Charlotte will learn to recognise the topics on the right quickly and move past them, so the time goes to questions she can answer.

Marks that do not need new content

Four habits, covered in week 1 and applied to every timed piece of work after it. At this level they are usually worth more than any single extra topic.

01

Method marks

Working earns marks even when the final answer is wrong. Every question gets a substitution line and visible steps, and nothing is rubbed out.

02

Always something written

A correct first step scores, and a blank does not. Every question gets at least one line, including the ones we have left out.

03

Two passes

The recognisable questions first, then back to anything flagged. Practised on every timed section from week 3, so it is familiar by November.

04

The last line

Marks are often lost at the end of correct work. Answers get checked for units, for degrees, and for the rounding the question asked for.

Every marked piece of work records marks lost to blanks, to missing working and to the final line. We review those three numbers in weeks 3 and 5.

BETWEEN SESSIONS

Twenty minutes a day, six days a week

This starts from the next session and runs to the exams. Six days a week for six weeks comes to about twelve hours, close to the total lesson time, and short daily sessions work better here than one long session at the weekend.

5 min

Target skill

Twenty questions on the week's target skill, written out in full and timed, with the score noted.

10 min

Mixed practice

Six questions from topics already covered, not grouped, so the method has to be chosen first.

5 min

Error log

Read through it, then redo two earlier errors without looking at the correction.

1

Nothing new is learned at home

2

Charlotte marks her own work

3

The same time each day

4

Sunday is five minutes, error log only

5

A photo of the marked sheet, sent the same day

We will look at how the daily work is going at the end of week 2.

It is the easiest part of the plan to lose and the hardest to make up. If twenty minutes is not fitting around everything else, please say so and we will adjust the plan around what is realistic.

PROGRESS

How we will track it

Two numbers: Charlotte's audit score, and her marks on a timed paper. Each checkpoint has a set response.

WEEK 1

Baseline

Audit and a full paper

Recorded as a starting point.

WEEK 3

Checkpoint 1

Audit repeated

The weakest skills should have improved.

WEEK 5

First full paper

35 / 100 or better

On track. If it is below, see the note underneath.

WEEK 6

Second full paper

40 / 100 or better

80 out of 200, 15 clear of the boundary.

If a number comes in low

- If the audit has not moved by week 3, the daily work is usually the cause, and we look at that first.
- Below 35 out of 100 in week 5, week 6 drops the third paper and goes back to the two weakest topics.
- Above 50 out of 100 in week 5, we add the single-step grade 6 topics.

AFTER EACH SESSION

A short note from me: what we covered, Charlotte's recall score out of six, and whether the daily work came back.

What could get in the way, and what we do

1 Entry not yet confirmed

The standard entry deadline for the November series was 12 September, so this needs checking with the school now. Late fees have applied since 13 September and rise again from 10 October.

2 A week is lost to illness

Week 6 carries the slack. The third full paper comes out first, then the pacing session. The teaching weeks stay as they are.

3 The daily work does not fit

We look at this at the end of week 2. If it is not working, week 5 shape content reduces to three topics and that time goes to number and algebra.

4 The audit is worse than expected

Weeks 2 and 3 stay as they are, and week 4 drops sequences and straight-line graphs. Number and algebra stay in.

Each of these has a response and a point at which we decide.

THE PLAN

Rebuild number and algebra first.

Cover about 105 marks of content and work towards 80.

Leave the rest out.

THIS WEEK

- 1 Check with the school that Charlotte is entered, and for which tier
- 2 Fluency audit and calculator setup in the next session
- 3 Baseline paper at home, and the error log set up

If anything here does not look right, please say and we will change it.